

RAJWANT RAWAT

Always on Track

Jaya Varma Sinha, *60*
Chairperson & CEO, Railway Board

ACCOMPLISHMENT
Did the firefighting in Delhi during the Balasore train accident

BEING THE FIRST-EVER HEAD of India's Railway Board—that monolithic, more than a century-old power centre once described by its own minister as "unwieldy" on the floor of Parliament—is but one of the many "firsts" in Jaya Varma Sinha's 35 years of service.

For instance, when she was appointed Railway Board Member (Operations & Business Development) in January 2023, she became the first-ever woman to head her cadre, the Indian Railway Traffic Service (IRTS). And a few years ago, when Jaya was directly in charge of India's freight transportation in the Railway Board, Indian Railways saw the highest-ever growth of 20-plus per cent, crossing the 1.5 billion tonne-mark of goods carried annually. She was also instrumental in creating the Freight Operations Information System in the '90s, the digital backbone for freight operations.

What Jaya loves about being a railwaywoman is how the organisation, with all its moving parts, rises to work as a cohesive whole in the face of adversity. Nowhere was it more evident than in Odisha's Balasore district in June 2023, when 295 passengers died in one of India's worst train accidents. As the then chairman and CEO of the Railway Board Anil Kumar Lahoti, and her boss, the railways minister Ashwini Vaishnaw, remained at the accident site for days, it fell on Jaya to brief Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union home minister Amit Shah and other bigwigs on what had gone wrong and what was being done. Sitting in Delhi, she supervised relief and rescue efforts and also faced the music in front of the media. Amid all that, she made sure trains ran normally in the rest of the country. Two months later, on August 31, a month before she was to retire, Jaya got the big job for a year, an 11-month extension of service. No one saw it coming.

It's been almost four decades since, after an MA in Psychology from Allahabad University, Jaya joined the Railways. It was at IRTS that she met her future husband Neeraj, though he went on to join the IPS. Jaya herself said no to IPS because the railways fascinated her, a decision she has never regretted: "It is the best job in terms of content and satisfaction." Throughout her career, she has deftly handled her job and home. How does she do it? For every officer, man or woman, she says, it is important to have interests beyond work "for overall growth as a person". On the rare occasions Jaya takes a break, you'll find her birdwatching or at home, reading books on history among other things, with some music playing in the background—Kishore Kumar, the Blues, folk. ■

–Avishek G. Dastidar

THE ONE TRUTH

"Don't be afraid of facing/telling the truth"

OFF DUTY
Loves birdwatching, along with friends, on the Ridge in Delhi. Takes pictures with her own DSLR camera